

Episode 46: For Some Reason This Week Is About "Lip Sync" Instead of "Colour"

Tokyo is in full cherry blossom bloom. Last week they reached full bloom all at once, and even in the park near my house, flower viewing parties continue from morning till morning (!) without pause (laugh). When I pass by the side of the park, the air smells of beer (bitter laugh).

At Toei Animation, staff room-level flower viewing parties have really decreased recently. Among this, I was invited to a "My Ham-gumi" flower viewing party just last week, but couldn't participate due to scheduling conflicts (crying). Hmm, too bad. I might end up finishing this year without any flower viewing parties...

I might have written this before, but back when *Saint Seiya* (聖闘士星矢) was still airing on TV, the *Saint Seiya* staff had a flower viewing party. A gathering under night cherry blossoms at Shakujii Park. At that gathering, chief director Morishita-san, getting into a good mood with beer, said this: "Cherry blossoms only come once a year. So being able to have flower viewing like this—maybe a few dozen times in a lifetime. That's all it is."

Ah, I think that's quite a profound statement.

Twenty years have passed since then, and every year around this time, I remember Morishita-san's words and feel a bit wistful. Thinking such thoughts, I went night cherry blossom viewing along the neighbourhood cherry tree avenue this year too.

Well then.

April is programmes revision season. The foreign drama slot on a certain commercial broadcaster's daytime programmes is one of my pleasures, but when I turned on the TV to watch *CSI:NY2*... huh? It's *Winter Sonata*! (sweat)

Surprised, I checked and found that the broadcast slot had moved starting this week. Three episodes per week became just one episode on Wednesdays... (crying). Well, I ended up watching "Winter Sonata" for the first time in several years (laugh). Yesterday was episode 1. Mm, it's still a masterpiece.

By the way, Korean dramas seem quite interesting, but I actually haven't watched many.

The reason is dubbing.

Korean people's facial features are basically very similar to ours, right? When those similar-looking people speak Japanese through "dubbing," the lip sync doesn't match (laugh). Well of course, they were originally speaking Korean (laugh). That creates a tremendous sense of incongruity that bothers me. For the same reason, I can't handle Chinese dramas with Japanese dubbing either. But if it's dubbed versions of American or European dramas, it doesn't bother me at all. I wonder if this is conditioning from childhood? (bitter laugh)

So when I watch Korean productions, I try to watch them with "subtitles + original audio" whenever possible.

And you know, this "lip sync" really bothers me in my work too (bitter laugh).

In most Japanese TV anime, lip sync uses three types: "closed mouth," "medium mouth (slightly open mouth state)," and "open mouth," repeating these randomly to make characters "talk." Considering real human mouth movements, without horizontally opening mouths and vertically opening mouths, it's absolutely insufficient from the start, but mysteriously, it somehow looks reasonably matched.

However, when impressive speech or shouted endings don't match the pronunciation and image, it's completely unacceptable. For example, shouting "Ahh!" but the mouth isn't "open mouth," or the final lip sync image being "closed mouth."

Even in TV productions, necessary cuts properly animate according to dialogue pronunciation, but in many cases they're animated with "closed mouth," "medium mouth," "open mouth" patterns.

When dubbing is finished and sound is attached, there's always a process of watching the entire main story from beginning to end to check everything, and we check for audio-visual mismatches there too. At that time, we request retakes for any lip sync that's particularly bothersome and fix what can be fixed.

I'm there to check colour-related things, but I end up pointing out those bothersome mismatches anyway. Some directors say "This is fine as is (laugh)," and maybe that's right, but... hmm, it bothers me! (bitter laugh)

There's something called "spotting" where the editor gives us timing like "open mouth starting at X seconds Y frames" to match sound/dialogue with images, and we reshoot according to that. Recently with digital editing, sometimes we can fix things by rearranging image order frame by frame on shot rush data, but usually it's a reshoot. Especially for something like *Hakaba Kitaro* (墓場鬼太郎) with continuous screen processing, it definitely requires reshooting.

Incidentally, during the old "co-production" American subcontracted works, we used the "pre-scoring" method where dialogue was recorded first and images were created to match it, so all "lip sync" timing was already marked on time sheets before animation began. Moreover, about seven types of "lip sync" models were determined to match English vowels, with all those instructions written on the sheets. So the images and dialogue matched perfectly.

Oh, pre-scoring is also used in Japan. For scenes with singing, performances, and dancing, it's "sound first," so it often becomes pre-scoring.

So I'm bothered by "lip sync" daily.

Now Japanese anime works are speaking in various languages around the world, but how is that? With just the "closed mouth," "medium mouth," "open mouth" pattern, aren't there many languages that don't match? And cuts that we animation-matched because Japanese mismatches bothered us become completely mismatched when dubbed (bitter laugh).

(...Ah, there's no colour discussion... (sweat))

(08.04.01)